



Every animal or plant is a potential dinner for another organism. But rather than surrendering to a grisly fate, many have developed weapons to fight back against a predator. These impressively dangerous spiky, sharp, or poisonous weapons are also used to catch food.

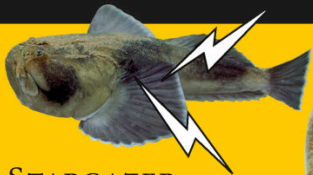
WIDOW
SPIDER



BEWARE—
I'M SMALL
BUT DEADLY!

Sting in the tail

Stings are another way to inject venom. They are usually found in the tails of scorpions and insects, such as bees and wasps, and are used to deter bigger animals or to kill smaller ones for food. Soft-bodied underwater animals also use stinging tentacles to zap anything that gets too close.



STARGAZER



TORPEDO
RAY

A prickly subject

Spikes and thorns are an effective deterrent against anything trying to wrap its jaws around you. Porcupines have stiff, hollow spines that they raise when threatened. In some fish, such as the lionfish or weever fish, the spines also deliver poison.

SPANISH
FESTOON
BUTTERFLY



*I'm not as tasty
as I look!*

CRAB



OTHER OFFENSIVE WEAPONS



Tarantulas can flick the hairs on their abdomen at opponents. The hairs are barbed and can irritate bare skin.



Skunks and stink badgers have glands at the base of the tail that contain a foul-smelling liquid which they can squirt up to 13 ft (4 m) quite accurately.



Boxer crabs often encourage stinging sea anemones to grow on their claws so they can wave them at enemies.



The Texas horned lizard squirts blood from a gland near the corner of its eye. The blood contains a foul-tasting chemical that repels all attackers.